

THE SORRY STATE



THE RISING: The movement's initial epicentre was West Bengal

MONA CHOUDHURY

FIRST CUT

• The first non-Congress ministry came to power in West Bengal as Ajoy Kumar Mukherjee was sworn in as chief minister of a United Front-Left Front alliance.

• The first Boeing 707-337C aircraft arrived in Bombay. This non-stop flight covered 4,931 miles between London and Bombay in seven hours and 54 minutes setting a new speed record for any Boeing.

As a land dispute broke out between peasants, led by Kanu Sanyal, a middle class radical, and landlords in Naxalbari, West Bengal, the area gave its name to a whole movement and indeed became a shorthand for revolution. It had an offshoot in Andhra Pradesh, where Maoist revolutionaries fought in Telengana and Srikakulam. In Srikakulam, the movement was headed by Vempatapu Satyanarayana and in Telengana by Tarimala Nagi Reddy. In West Bengal, the CPM, which had stoked the Naxalbari fire, eventually came to be at loggerheads with the Naxalites who formed a new party, CPI (Marxist-Leninist). The protests, said historian Ramachandra Guha, had their roots in the inequitable agrarian structure of northern Bengal. "But they may not have taken the form they did, had the CPM not joined the government." The party reacted in an authoritarian way by putting Sanyal in jail while other rebels took refuge in the jungle.

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Tamil Nadu, India's sixth most populous state, was formed in 1967. The DMK routed the Congress Party in the 1967 elections and took control of the state, with C.N. Annadurai as its first chief minister.